

The Rite of Empowerment

Śekaparakriyā · Toh 365 · Derge Kangyur

དབང་གི་རབ་ཏུ་བྱེད་པ།

Toh 365 in the Kangyur is a tantric ritual text known in Sanskrit as the Śekaparakriyā and in Tibetan as the Rite of Empowerment, or Dbang gi rab tu byed pa. It is a liturgical and instructional work concerned with the conferral of empowerments, describing in detail the ceremonies by which disciples are introduced into a maṇḍala, consecrated through vase and other empowerments, and bound by the appropriate vows and precepts. The text invokes the compassionate bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara and proceeds through the stages of ripening initiates into particular tantric families, outlining the ritual actions, symbolic adornments, and ethical commitments — including the five precepts against killing, false speech, taking another's consort, theft, and intoxicants — that govern those who enter the path. As a work belonging to the tantric or Vajrayāna portion of the Kangyur, it represents the kind of practical ceremonial manual that would guide a qualified master in conducting empowerment rites within the context of Buddhist tantric tradition.

Translated and edited for monks, and finalized.

In Sanskrit: Śekaparakriyā. In Tibetan: The Rite of Empowerment. Homage to the greatly compassionate noble Avalokiteśvara.

After the vase empowerment has been conferred, the Victors protect their own disciples, who have been ripened into their own families, at the head, the heart, the crown of the head, the navel, the throat, and the secret place, with their own three vajras. The disciples' bodies are adorned with a yellow cloth, their eyes are covered, and they are led into this maṇḍala.

For those who are truly supreme and who have entered the path on the conventional level, the vows are always to be given. Killing, speaking falsely, taking another's consort, and likewise taking another's wealth and drinking intoxicants — these five sins are like a vajra-noose of cyclic existence that destroys one's own virtue.

By the word of the teacher who is a god among men, who arose at a particular time, and whose name was given at the ceremony, the fearfulness of existence is vanquished; you too should uphold this.

Always guard against: sharing ornaments, blameworthy food, reading harmful speech, and the teachings of elemental spirits, asuras, and non-Buddhists; and do not kill cattle, children, women, men, gods, humans, or the five kinds of spiritual teachers.

Do not steal from companions, lords, divine and human spiritual teachers, or the Saṅgha. The twenty-five vows of the master of existence are not to be craved by those who have completely given up the senses.

For the glorious praise of the mantra, one flower is offered with palms joined. One first circumambulates three times, then casts the flower held between the joined palms into the maṇḍala. The place where that fine flower falls — that is the family to which this person belongs, O lords of men.

Thereafter, the seven empowerments and three kinds are fully and perfectly conferred, without exception, in their proper forms. The victorious conqueror vase — filled by nāgas and the four kinds — whether it be a jewel vase or a golden vase, adorned with precious medicine and fragrance drawn from the earth, the goddesses use it for the bathing.

The distinguished divisions of the buddhas invoke the crown ornament; the supreme teacher, with the silk streamers of empowerment; the vajra and bell for sun and moon; and through the vows the objects and the senses are to be purified. By name, the wrathful ones, Maitreya and the rest, together with the permission of the lord of Victors, and the conclusion — these are bestowed. Having conferred the vajra and bell, the pure teachings are demonstrated through supreme compassion.

For those determined to be of the vajra family: the act of taking life, speaking false words with a blade, and for the jewel family, seizing another's wealth. For the supreme lotus family, taking another's consort. For the wheel family: intoxicants, lamps, all the buddhas, and all realms are to be relied upon thoroughly. For the curved knife: women of low caste and all other women — the lotus of the sky is not to be disparaged.

For the sake of sentient beings, wealth and body together are to be given. This is not something you are to protect as your own. Sons of the family, the Victors have definitively declared that even over countless eons one will not become a buddha otherwise.

With water: Tārā and the other goddesses, the crown-adorned Victors, the silk streamers, and the empowerments — the sun, moon, vajra, bell, the vows with

their objects and the rest, and by name Maitreya and the rest — all are to be purified.

The permission empowerment of glorious perfect awakening, the destroyer of the fear of existence, Kālacakra (the Wheel of Time), pervades all that follows. Thus, through the seven empowerments, which destroy the stain of sin, one is perfectly established within the very maṇḍala itself.

When the seven empowerments are conferred, by the power of their virtue one becomes sovereign over the seven grounds.

Thereafter, one is definitively introduced to irreversibility and the rest. Through the conferral of the vase empowerment, the secret empowerment, and the wisdom-gnosis empowerments, one becomes Mañjuśrī himself, the destroyer of the fear of existence.

Through the empowerment of the feigned conduct of beings, if a root downfall occurs, in this very life the suffering of hell will arise. But if a root downfall occurs, one who abides in the seven empowerments and possesses good qualities may purify it through recitation.

If, in the vase and secret empowerments, the vow with its certain observance is taken, there is no purification from higher to lower. One in whom a root downfall has occurred should be introduced into this very maṇḍala for the purpose of purification.

One who has received only a permission empowerment and later goes among an assembly of the lineage is called, relative to an elder, the younger.

Root downfalls committed by disciples — the first being the wounding of the glorious guru's heart — make one into the Bearer of the Hare (the Moon). Transgressing that one's commands is another; anger toward one's vajra-siblings is certainly the third. Abandoning loving-kindness is the fourth; and further, the one that comes from utterly abandoning the awakening mind itself.

Disparaging a philosophical school is the sixth; and further, giving secret teachings to those not yet ripened among ordinary beings is like a mountain. Being transformed into a nāga through the afflictions of the aggregates is another; and the ninth is lack of faith in the authentic Dharma.

Directing the illusory loving-kindness, granting bliss free from names and the like, and whatever conception is forceful — these are related to the tenth. Openly proclaiming faults to pure sentient beings is like the sun — another is

abandoning the samaya substance received. Certainly disparaging all women causes one to be a miser; and these belong to those who abide in the Vajra Vehicle.

In the first phase of a year, up to ten aspects, there should be gazing and touching. After that, those to be embraced — the ocean consorts and those endowed with flavor — are to be relied upon through movement and so forth. The lower mudrās below the twentieth year are of the class of asuras, of the supremely terrifying wrathful elemental beings. For the purpose of empowerment, through sets of six and three they bestow the fruit of equal bliss; the rest is for the purpose of meditation.

One who first touches the glorious wisdom-consort as a younger sister — that itself is called the vase empowerment. Having tasted the Bearer of the Hare and having caused the secret to be seen, that becomes the secret empowerment.

All the limbs are to be purified through the lineage of all the Victors, and the wisdom-gnosis empowerment is to be given. Having made the Victor a hero, for the sake of the disciple the mudrā is to be given — and also here, for the guru as well: a beautiful girl of twelve years of age, like unto molten gold adorned with all ornaments. One who is endowed with the nature of method and wisdom should practice with one's own vajra-jewel with attachment. Knowing the disciple to be pure, the vajra seed included, one should cause it to enter correctly into the mouth. Afterward, having given one's own mudrā to the child, and even if further endowed with the path of smoke and the like —

Those with frightened and confused minds, with deceitfulness and being under another's control, with children within, with anger, arrogance, attachment to desires, lying, fondness for quarreling, decline of limbs, and impurity — such as these, even with extreme effort in the wisdom-gnosis empowerment, are to be rejected by the guru as those who are not capable.

Again it is said: toward buddha-gurus, one should be respectful, maintain samaya, pay homage, and make offerings. The very minds of beings are stirred and filled by attachment and desire. From the fullness of the supreme limb, through the blazing, the Bearer of the Hare melts and truly drips. Having drawn up the oḍḍiyāna fully, it bestows supreme bliss — at the culmination of the three liberated bindus. Appearance, touch, union, transformation, and bliss — thus it is, through the divisions of joy and so forth.

At first, when all people have looked with their eyes, this stirs attachment and desire — that is joy. Then, when the fullness gathers fully into one's own body, that becomes supreme joy.

Through the blazing and the genuine play, from the vajra the bindu drips into the lotus — that is the third joy, the distinctive joy. From the oḍḍiyāna vajra, at the boundary of the three bindus, bliss transforms into the innate joy — that is the fourth joy.

Desire, joy, agitation, and non-transformation — through these four, the union of that one is single. Fullness, capacity, and certain arising — these two together constitute supreme joy, the second. Blazing, bindus, and flowing — these three together constitute the distinctive joy, the third. Oḍḍiyāna, sound alone, and sleep — together with the innately arisen, these four constitute the fourth joy.

What is to be thought with the mind is not this; rather, by touching and embracing it becomes a sister. When the vajra has fully entered, she is spoken of as a girl; through the act itself there is great bliss, and likewise warmth. When the bindu falls, she becomes a wife; separated from attachment, she becomes the yoginī who has entered another's family.

Thus the six yoga mudrās are: the actual substances of earth, water, fire, wind, and space. The sequence for the lotus is the full entry of the vajra; for fire, wind; and the bindu does not fall — in this order. Thus, through the clear manifestation of the three yogas, the mudrā of body, speech, and mind is definitively established.

Attachment and freedom from attachment, the extreme — and previously, the treasury of supreme bliss — by union the fourth armor is complete. Among all the mudrās the ten aspects that have become the supreme mother are the very words of the glorious guru.

The seven aspects and the three aspects — these ten — constitute the worldly, conventional authority. In the same way it has also been said: the fourth. The fourth is not the wisdom and gnosis of the third, because it is stated to be the fourth — the transcendent authority — and because it was also said: likewise.

Here the Blessed One declared: One who has touched the breast of wisdom, and who has also tasted the nectar and embraced it — and through the union with wisdom, the awakening mind melts into nectar in four instants — all of

these are definitively taught by the supreme compassion as causes of the worldly path.

As for the transcendent authority, it is to be cultivated as follows: it is the Victor's own supreme mudrā of virtue, accompanied by it; the karma-mudrā (mudrā of action), being tainted, causes distraction of the mind, and the wisdom mudrā is conceptual thought — these having been fully abandoned, for the cause of perfect awakening one should meditate on the excellent supreme mudrā which engenders the supreme Victor.

Unstained, unchanging, dispelling all darkness, all-pervading, equal to space — this is what the yogi is to understand. The gnosis that dwells in the body, resplendent, purifying the stain of existence, pervaded by the wheel of time — it is certainly nothing but a mere luminosity of the mind, arisen from one's own mind-stream, like a reflection in a mirror.

When all bodhisattvas without exception and all buddhas have relied upon it, and when the lords of yoga who have relied upon it cause that very luminosity of wisdom to dawn brilliantly — thereby all the armies of Māra together with their domains are utterly burned, and those such as those with attachment, by engaging the yogis in union for a year in the body, bestow equal bliss.

Wisdom and gnosis — this is nothing other than the luminosity of mind, and that too becomes tenfold in aspect. Whoever has entered into this authority — it is to be understood as like the stainless moon, like a mirror's reflection. Then, bliss without dripping, innate, unchanging, the fourth — one touches nirvāṇa. Therefore the face of the buddhas: whoever abides in their mind and in their presence — that itself is the glorious guru.

Through those who, with a mind attached to sky-like openness and with unblinking eyes, have fully entered into the vajra path — from emptiness there clearly appears smoke, a mirage, a firefly, a flame carried by fire, a lamp, blazing fire, sun, moon, vajras — and still others: the supreme aspect and the bindus themselves. In the midst of all this, the body of the buddha, freed from objects and aspects, is the manifold sambhogakāya.

The view to be held in the sky free from clouds is to be gazed upon with the view of one-pointed yoga.

For as long as one certainly sees dark markings with spotless radiating light — that is through the channel of time. There the body of omniscience appears, like a sun within water, unstained and of manifold colors.

The aspects that are entirely free of object and of subject are nothing other than one's own mind — they are not another's mind.

Once the body has been seen, on each successive day, when the vital breath has been thoroughly restrained, practitioners endowed with conduct — through six months the mind of the path, freed from tactile sensation, becomes blissful equanimity.

For as long as one certainly sees rays of light circling around one's own body like a wheel, from the very first moment that goes toward the extremes of attachment and non-attachment, the count of the breaths of the all-pervasive breath increases.

At the extremity, in the blazing center — the distinction, joy, co-emergent joy, gnosis and consciousness, in the center of sleep and swoon — the bliss of union produced by vajra and lotus together: without any doubt, through the definite power of the guru, there is no doubt this very bliss increases.

A yogin who conquers māras and afflictions and abides in the lordship of the Victor, through one year of practice — what appears as earth is not solid, what appears as the form of water is not water and has no moisture, what appears as fire is not fire, what appears as the form of wind is not wind since it does not move. Though it has the aspect of emptiness it is seen; though white, blue and other colors are seen, it is not various hues. Though it is endowed with all aspects, it is not seen — because of the defilements of one's own mind, of the afflictions, and of the power and force of māras.

Mere sound, bindu, aspects, and gnoses go to the abode of nectar, and the channels bound by iron fetters — together with the life-breath and the downward-clearing breath, along the three paths, through vajra-and-lotus together and lotus-and-vajra — when the winds moving in the center enter, gather, and unite, object and subject dissolve, and the signs such as smoke and the rest — whatever apprehends them and all that grasps at them — this is the Great Secret.

Drawing the life-force into the center: the right and left — which have become sun and moon — are bound together; through the mind of mudrā and union one becomes supremely blissful, the vajra is truly aroused, and for the sake of supreme bliss the vajra moves within the lotus, or the lotus is rubbed by one's own hand — that bliss, without emission of the seed, conquers the fear of death: that itself is the face of the glorious guru.

Earth dissolves into water, water likewise into fire, and fire dissolves into wind. Wind dissolves into emptiness; emptiness becomes the ten signs with their aspects; the signs with all their aspects do not change — supreme and indestructible bliss becomes the wisdom body.

From the gnosis of the lord of men, miraculous powers and siddhis arise — in this very birth of beings, through desire, one certainly becomes an emanation body, and fullness perfected becomes supremely manifest as Speech.

The blazing emanation is the mind: from Oḍḍiyāna, it is called "the gnosis that creates supreme bliss." Joy is the saṃbhogakāya — supreme joy, special joy, and ordinary joy together — through their gradation, Speech and Mind: from co-emergent joy and so forth, gnosis-vajra and the rest arise.

Movement is certainly the dharmakāya, and the speech arising from it is that which receives the homage of the three realms. Sleep is certainly the dharmakāya's mind — the fourth state — that gnosis itself conquers the fears of existence.

Syllables are certainly the pure body — through the sequence of vowel-free aspects, bindus, and mere sound — Speech, Mind, gnosis-vajra: abiding in the three levels of existence, they are made to arise as the pure body.

Waking and dream — each in its own nature — and likewise deep sleep and the nature of the fourth state; the body's abiding, the dissolution of the breath, movement throughout, and the dissolution of mind that is moved away from objects and domains:

Even while gnosis remains present, the moment when the awakening mind melts through union with a woman — through emanation and the rest, in sequence, the mind-vajra (Skt. cittavajra) becomes established without doubt in its four aspects.

Thus mind in its four aspects, dwelling in the bindu at the center of the living beings of the three levels of existence — pervasive, bestowing bliss and equanimity, a cause of liberation — is something that those who are masters of yoga must guard. If the seed-bindu is released in order to produce supreme bliss for yogins, how could liberation come from that? Therefore those who hold to vows must always and continuously abandon this momentary bliss of saṃsāra.

This concludes the condensed empowerment text drawn from the glorious Kālacakra, being a thousand verses and more than thirty stanzas from the

Kālacakra cycle.

Translated and revised, and brought to finality by the great learned Indian paṇḍita Samantaśrī and the Tibetan translator, the monk Chörab.

Translator's Notes

- This passage is an introductory liturgical text for the Kālacakra empowerment ceremony, specifically the Śekaparakriyā, a ritual procedural text describing the stages of initiation. The title appears in Sanskrit transliteration in the Tibetan as Śekaparakriyā, meaning "the procedure of empowerment" or "the rite of consecration." The five sins enumerated are the five root transgressions in the tantric vow system: killing, lying, taking another's consort, stealing, and drinking intoxicants. The "twenty-five vows of the master of existence" is a reference to the twenty-five bodhisattva vows associated specifically with the Kālacakra tantra system. The "three vajras" refers to the body, speech, and mind of the guru as buddha-vajra, dharma-vajra, and saṅgha-vajra. The passage listing transgressions keyed to different families — vajra, jewel, lotus, wheel — reflects the standard fourfold or fivefold family system of Kālacakra. The line about sons of the family not attaining buddhahood over countless eons without following these precepts is a standard tantric admonition about the necessity of tantric path over sūtra path alone.

- The passage enumerates the fourteen root downfalls of the Vajrayāna, a standard doctrinal list; the enumeration here follows the Kālacakra tradition, which differs slightly from other tantric systems. The ninth and tenth are somewhat compressed in the source and the rendering tracks the grammar closely.

The term translated as "Bearer of the Hare" refers to the moon, a standard Indic kenning: the moon is said to bear the image of a hare on its face. In context the moon also serves as a substance used in tantric practice, and the phrase "the Bearer of the Hare melts" refers to the melting of the lunar bindu (vital drop) in the channels.

"Oḍḍiyāna" here is the Tibetan transliteration of the Sanskrit Oḍḍiyāna, referring both to the sacred site and to a specific yogic technique of drawing upward; the context here points to the latter.

The four joys enumerated at the close — joy, supreme joy, special joy, and innate joy — are a standard Kālacakra and Anuttarayoga classification; the text gives only the first two explicitly here.

- The six yoga mudrās passage lists correspondences between mudrā types and the five elements plus space; the assignment of "lotus" to earth and "fire" to fire follows the tantra's internal symbolic logic rather than a standard external commentary, and the lines are terse to the point of ellipsis. The rendering keeps the sequence explicit but the underlying ritual identification is not fully transparent from the text alone.

The closing catalogue of visionary appearances — smoke, mirage, firefly, lamp, and so forth — echoes the standard set of inner signs familiar from the Kālacakra and related completion-stage literature, though the order here differs slightly from the most common canonical lists.

- The term rendered "the fourth state" for Tibetan ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ is a transliteration of Sanskrit turīya, the classical designation for the fourth state of consciousness beyond waking, dream, and deep sleep. This is a significant technical term in the tantric context and worth noting.

The passage describes tantric physical and meditative practices in technical detail: the "vajra and lotus" symbolism refers to the male and female sexual ritual implements or organs; "without emission of seed" indicates the tantric practice of retaining the seminal essence. The geography of "channels, winds, and bindus" is standard Vajrayāna subtle-body physiology.

The line "from Oḍḍiyāna" renders འུ་འུ་ཡོ་ as a toponym — Oḍḍiyāna, a sacred region associated with tantric origins. This reading is reasonably certain in context.

- The term "turya" (Sanskrit turīya, "the fourth state," the transcendent state beyond waking, dreaming, and deep sleep) is retained as a recognizable Sanskrit term since the Tibetan is a direct transliteration and the concept is technically specific. The phrase "union with a woman" renders the Tantric technical context of the melting of bodhicitta during sexual yoga practice; this is the doctrinal point being warned against in the final verse, which cautions that releasing the seed-bindu in this way is incompatible with liberation. The colophon names the translator as "Chörab" (Chos rab), a monk and lotsāwa working with the Indian paṇḍita Samantaśrī.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.